

GENDER

Vedwati Padwal Vs. Pankaj Juvekar



BENDERS



Acronym Soup

00:02:30

This month's task was to say what three acronyms stood for—LCD, TCP and OLED. We figured these were in increasing order of “difficulty”, so to speak. A quiz of sorts. When we fired “LCD” at Vedwati, she was caught off-guard. She did recover a little, though—her first letter was bang on: “Liquid”. Then she fumbled, and a little cogitation got her saying that “D” stood for “display”. The “C” had her flummoxed, and we had to tell her. “TCP” was too much for her to handle, and from the look on her face, we felt we would hit a wall if we went on with “OLED”. Vedwati was only too happy to know she could leave!

00:02:11

A confident Pankaj, faced with “LCD”, stuttered, “LCD: Liquefied Crystal... err... Display.” Sounded too chemical for us, so we corrected him. Our next acronym—TCP—saw him give up without a fight! Kind as we are, we supplied him with a couple of clues, but he just didn't seem to get it. Still, based on whatever he'd said, we thought we'd fire our last salvo—OLED. Pankaj knew it had something to do with “display”, but didn't really have a clue beyond that. Then we told him.

Pankaj wins by a small margin—but after he'd left, we did have ourselves a good but guilty laugh at his “liquefied”! Sorry, Pankaj, if you're reading this...



spanning the last 30 years of environmental disasters. On a happier note, a partnership with Discovery Networks will allow people to take a virtual world holiday tour. Other partners in the new programme—which Google is calling “featured content”—include the Jane Goodall Institute (www.janegoodall.org). Using this overlay, people can visit the Gombe preserve chimpanzees and follow their daily activities, in Google Earth, with the Institute's “geo-blog”.

You can access the featured-content layer by clicking “Featured Content” in the Google Earth sidebar. More at <http://earth.google.com/earth4-beta4.html>.

YOU FEEL LIKE BUYING

Introducing: Spam For Your Subconscious

Security software and anti-virus company Panda Software in September found what they believe is subliminal advertising in spam.

Subliminal advertising is a technique that was used on TV and in movies a long time ago, and was subsequently banned in such countries as Australia, the US, and the UK. “Subliminal” means that a message appears on

screen for a very short duration—measured in milliseconds—and, according to psychologists, the message reaches down to the subconscious mind of the viewer, meaning the viewer is not “really” aware of it.

The message may appear once or several times, and typically suggest an action the company wants the viewer to take. Since they appeal to the subconscious, such messages have a more powerful effect, according to some.

The spam message Panda Software claims to have found offers the user an opportunity to buy certain stocks online. The subliminal message included was a sequence of images that show the word “Buy” at different screen positions, for a maximum of 40 milliseconds, and in some cases, for only 10, according to some reports.

Luis Corrons, director of PandaLabs, said: “This is the first time we have detected an Internet threat that uses subliminal techniques... It is worrying to witness how cyber-criminals are trying to introduce new strategies to increase the effectiveness of their attacks... We can expect new and more sophisticated threats of this kind to appear.”

There are several aspects to look at here. First is the very question of whether subliminal techniques in advertising actually work or not: even the experts are not in agreement on this point.

Then, if we do assume that they work, how

effective will they be in conjunction with spam? Attention needs to be focused on what is displayed, and this is hardly the case with spam: when someone opens a junk e-mail message, it is usually by mistake, and therefore, as soon as he or she discovers it is spam, the message is likely to be deleted, without enough attention having been paid to it.

Another factor is the products that spam mails promote: if it's for Viagra, for example, a user is hardly likely to be influenced by a subliminal “Buy”; we could possibly believe that such techniques work for products such as an Xbox, with the words “PS3 sucks!” as the subliminal message.

However, if what PandaLabs says is to be believed, this could mean a new dimension for spam.

Assuming everyone doesn't have a spam filter installed, that is; in which case, we must doff our hats to the spammers for having come up with the idea.

There is also controversy on whether the ad that Panda detected really does have a subliminal message, because there are different opinions on what constitutes one.

Some say, for example, that the word “Buy” appeared for too long to be considered subliminal.

We must ask, then, if this “discovery” is just a move on Panda Software's part to get into the news a bit.

iTV

This is being called by some a “stab in the heart for Microsoft.” It is a new offering from Apple that will be launched in the first quarter of 2007. It looks like a portable DVD player, and it's essentially a video-streaming set-top box—more like a wireless router—that takes content from a Mac, PC or iPod, and displays it on a TV set.

The system will also allow one to stream movies or TV programmes from Apple's online iTunes store. iTV incorporates Dolby surround, but due to the limitations of high-speed data transfer even with true broadband connections, when it comes to streaming movies, home theatre users will have to do with a “near-DVD-quality” picture.

Buzzword
of the MONTH